

VacationsForYOU

AI Guest Support Assistant

Developer User Manual

This report is completed in accordance with the Software Engineering Body of Knowledge (SWEBOK)

1. Introduction

This manual provides step-by-step instructions for setting up, running, testing, and maintaining the VacationsForYOU AI Guest Support Assistant. It is intended for the next development team to pick up this project after Phase 1.

The system is a conversational AI chatbot that helps vacation rental guests before and after booking. It answers questions about properties, policies, amenities, and reservations using a RAG pipeline backed by the company's call center manual and the StreamlineVRS property management system.

Before you start: make sure you have Python 3.10+, Node.js 18+, and Git installed on your machine.

2. System Requirements

Component	Requirement
Operating System	Windows 10/11, macOS 12+, or Ubuntu 22+
Python	3.10 or higher
Node.js	18 or higher
npm	8 or higher
Git	Any recent version
Browser	Chrome, Firefox, Edge, or Safari (latest)
OpenAI Account	Active account with billing enabled at platform.openai.com
StreamlineVRS	Token key and secret from sponsor. IP must be whitelisted.

3. Installation & First-Time Setup

3.1 Clone the Repository

1. Open a terminal and navigate to where you want the project.

2. Run the following command:

```
git clone https://github.com/CGrogan4/vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant.git
```

3. Navigate into the project:

```
cd vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant
```

4. Navigate to the backend folder:

```
cd backend
```

5. Create a virtual environment:

```
python -m venv venv
```

6. Activate the virtual environment:

Windows:

```
.\venv\Scripts\activate
```

Mac / Linux:

```
source venv/bin/activate
```

You should see (venv) at the start of your terminal prompt.

7. Install all backend dependencies:

```
pip install flask flask-cors openai python-dotenv requests langchain  
langchain-openai langchain-community langchain-chroma chromadb pypdf
```

Always make sure (venv) is showing before running pip install or py commands. Installing outside the venv will cause conflicts.

```
PROBLEMS OUTPUT DEBUG CONSOLE TERMINAL PORTS GITLENS powershell - backend + - [ ] [ ] ...

PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant> cd backend
PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\backend> (Set-ExecutionPolicy -Scope Process -ExecutionPolicy RemoteSigned) ; (& c:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\venv\Scripts\Activate.ps1)
(venv) PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\backend> python -m venv venv
(venv) PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\backend> .\venv\Scripts\activate
(venv) PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\backend>

(venv) PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\backend> pip install flask flask-cors openai python-dotenv requests langchain langchain-openai langchain-community langchain-chroma chromadb pypdf

Downloading xhash-3.7.0-cp314-cp314-win-amd64.whl (32 kB)
Using cached zipp-3.23.1-py3-none-any.whl (10 kB)
Downloading zstandard-0.25.0-cp314-cp314-win-amd64.whl (516 kB)
Using cached flatbuffers-25.12.19-py2.py3-none-any.whl (26 kB)
Using cached importlib_resources-7.1.0-py3-none-any.whl (37 kB)
Using cached pyproject_hooks-1.2.0-py3-none-any.whl (10 kB)
Using cached requests_oauthlib-2.0.0-py2.py3-none-any.whl (24 kB)
Using cached oauthlib-3.3.1-py3-none-any.whl (160 kB)
Installing collected packages: pypika, flatbuffers, durationpy, zstandard, zipp, xhash, websockets, websocket-client, uuid-utils, tenacity, six, shellin-gham, regex, pyyaml, pyproject hooks, pypdf, pygments, pybase64, protobuf, propcache, packaging, overrides, ormsgpack, orjson, oauthlib, numpy, mpy-extensions, multidict, mmh3, mdurl, langchain-protocol, jsonpointer, importlib-resources, httpx-sse, httpxtools, hf-xet, grpcio, greenlet, fsspec, frozenlist, filelock, bcrypt, annotated-doc, aiohappyeyeballs, yarl, watchfiles, uvicorn, typing-inspect, tiktoken, SQLAlchemy, requests-toolbelt, requests-oauthlib, python-dateutil, opentelemetry-proto, onnxruntime, marshmallow, markdown-it-py, jsonpatch, importlib-metadata, googleapis-common-protos, build, aiosignal, al, rich, pydantic-settings, opentelemetry-exporter-otlp-proto-common, opentelemetry-api, langsmith, langgraph-sdk, kubernetes, dataclasses-json, aiohttp, typer, opentelemetry-semantic-conventions, langchain-core, opentelemetry-sdk, langgraph-checkpoint, langchain-text-splitters, langchain-openai, huggingface-hub, tokenizers, opentelemetry-exporter-otlp-proto-grpc, langgraph-prebuilt, langchain-classic, langgraph, langchain-community, chromadb, langchain-chroma, langchain
Successfully installed SQLAlchemy-2.0.49 aiohappyeyeballs-2.6.1 aiohttp-3.13.5 aiosignal-1.4.0 annotated-doc-0.0.4 bcrypt-5.0.0 build-1.5.0 chromadb-1.5.9 dataclasses-json-0.6.7 durationpy-0.10 filelock-3.29.0 flatbuffers-25.12.19 frozenlist-1.8.0 fsspec-2026.4.0 googleapis-common-protos-1.74.0 greenlet-3.5.0 grpcio-1.80.0 hf-xet-1.5.0 httpxtools-0.7.1 httpx-sse-0.4.3 huggingface-hub-1.14.0 importlib-metadata-8.7.1 importlib-resources-7.1.0 jsonpatch-1.33 jsonpointer-3.1.1 kubernetes-35.0.0 langchain-1.2.17 langchain-chroma-1.1.0 langchain-classic-1.0.6 langchain-community-0.4.1 langchain-core-1.3.3 langchain-openai-1.2.1 langchain-protocol-0.0.15 langchain-text-splitters-1.1.2 langgraph-1.1.10 langgraph-checkpoint-4.0.3 langgraph-prebuilt-1.0.13 langgraph-sdk-0.3.14 langsmith-0.8.2 markdown-it-py-4.1.0 marshmallow-3.26.2 mdurl-0.1.2 mmh3-5.2.1 multidict-6.7.1 mpy-extensions-1.1.0 numpy-2.4.4 oauthlib-3.3.1 onnxruntime-1.25.1 opentelemetry-api-1.41.1 opentelemetry-exporter-otlp-proto-common-1.41.1 opentelemetry-exporter-otlp-proto-grpc-1.41.1 opentelemetry-proto-1.41.1 opentelemetry-sdk-1.41.1 opentelemetry-semantic-conventions-0.62b1 orjson-3.11.9 ormsgpack-1.12.2 overrides-7.7.0 packaging-26.2 propcache-0.4.1 protobuf-6.33.6 pybase64-1.4.3 pydantic-settings-2.14.0 pygments-2.20.0 pypdf-6.10.2 pypika-0.51.1 pyproject hooks-1.2.0 python-dateutil-2.9.0.post0 pyyaml-6.0.3 regex-2026.4.4 requests-oauthlib-2.0.0 requests-toolbelt-1.0.0 rich-15.0.0 shellingham-1.5.4 six-1.17.0 tenacity-9.1.4 tiktoken-0.12.0 toml-0.10.2 tokenizers-0.23.1 typer-0.25.1 typing-inspect-0.9.0 uuid-utils-0.14.1 uvicorn-0.46.0 watchfiles-1.1.1 websocket-client-1.9.0 websockets-16.0 xhash-3.7.0 yarl-1.23.0 zipp-3.23.1 zstandard-0.25.0

[notice] A new release of pip is available: 25.3 -> 26.1.1
[notice] To update, run: python.exe -m pip install --upgrade pip
(venv) PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\backend>
```

3.3 Configure Environment Variables

8. In the backend folder, create a new file called .env
9. Copy the contents of .env.example into .env
10. Fill in your real values:

```
OPENAI_API_KEY=sk-your-openai-key-here
STREAMLINE_TOKEN_KEY= your_token_key_here
STREAMLINE_TOKEN_SECRET= your_token_secret_here
STREAMLINE_BASE_URL=
```

.env must never be committed to GitHub. Confirm it appears in .gitignore before pushing.

3.4 Load the Call Center Manual (RAG Setup)

11. Obtain VFYmanual.pdf from the previous team lead.
12. Place it in the backend/ folder.
13. Run the ingest script:

```
py ingest.py
```

You should see: Loading manual... Loaded X pages. Created X chunks. Building Vector Store... Vector store built and saved. Manual successfully loaded into vector stores!

You only need to run ingest.py once per machine, or whenever VFYmanual.pdf is updated.

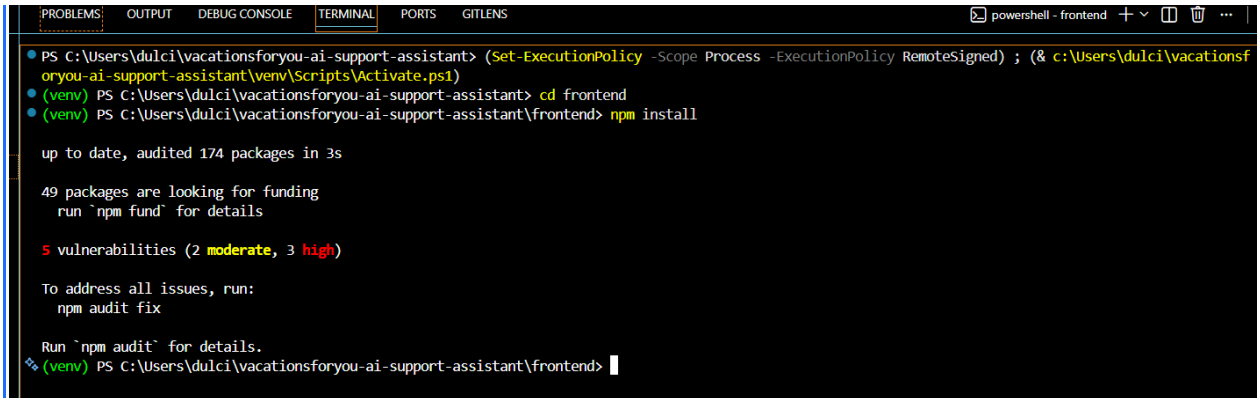
3.5 Set Up the Frontend

14. Open the second terminal window.

15. Navigate to the frontend folder:

```
cd frontend
```

16. Install Node dependencies:

A screenshot of a Visual Studio Code terminal window. The terminal title bar shows 'powershell - frontend'. The terminal content shows a series of commands and their outputs. The first command is a PowerShell command to set the execution policy. The second command is 'cd frontend'. The third command is 'npm install'. The output of 'npm install' shows that 174 packages were audited in 3 seconds, 49 packages are looking for funding, and there are 5 vulnerabilities (2 moderate, 3 high). It also suggests running 'npm audit fix' to address all issues. The terminal ends with a prompt for the user to run 'npm audit' for details.

```
PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant> (Set-ExecutionPolicy -Scope Process -ExecutionPolicy RemoteSigned) ; (& c:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\venv\Scripts\Activate.ps1)
(venv) PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant> cd frontend
(venv) PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\frontend> npm install

up to date, audited 174 packages in 3s

49 packages are looking for funding
  run `npm fund` for details

5 vulnerabilities (2 moderate, 3 high)

To address all issues, run:
  npm audit fix

Run `npm audit` for details.
(venv) PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\frontend>
```

```
npm install
```

4. Running the Application

You need two terminals running simultaneously — one for the backend and one for the frontend.

4.1 Start the Backend

In your backend terminal with (venv) active:

```
py chatbot.py
```

You should see:

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\backend> py chatbot.py
C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\backend\venv\Lib\site-packages\langchain_core\api\deprecation.py:25: UserWarning: Core Pydantic V1 f
unctionality isn't compatible with Python 3.14 or greater.
  from pydantic.v1.fields import FieldInfo as FieldInfoV1
Vector store loaded successfully!
* Serving Flask app 'chatbot'
* Debug mode: on
WARNING: This is a development server. Do not use it in a production deployment. Use a production WSGI server instead.
* Running on http://127.0.0.1:5000
Press CTRL+C to quit
* Restarting with stat
C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\backend\venv\Lib\site-packages\langchain_core\api\deprecation.py:25: UserWarning: Core Pydantic V1 f
unctionality isn't compatible with Python 3.14 or greater.
  from pydantic.v1.fields import FieldInfo as FieldInfoV1
Vector store loaded successfully!
* Debugger is active!
* Debugger PIN: 931-081-769
Vector store loaded successfully! * Serving Flask app 'chatbot' * Running on
http://127.0.0.1:5000
```

Keep this terminal open. If you close it the chatbot will stop working.

4.2 Start the Frontend

In your frontend terminal:

```
npm run dev
```

You should see:

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\frontend> npm install
(venv) PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\frontend> npm run dev

> frontend@0.0.0 dev
> vite

VITE v8.0.0 ready in 732 ms

→ Local:   http://localhost:5173/
→ Network: use --host to expose
→ press h + enter to show help

VITE v8.0.0 ready in 288 ms   Local:   http://localhost:5173/
```

4.3 Open the Application

17. Open your browser and go to <http://localhost:5173>
18. You should see a blank page with a  button in the corner.
19. Click the  button to open the chat widget.
20. You should see the welcome message: "Welcome to Vacations For You!"



Vacations For YOU

AI Support Agent – here with all your travel needs

Welcome to Vacations For You! Ask about bookings, properties, check-in times, or cancellations. I'm here to help with all your travel needs.



04:33 PM

Write a message...

Send



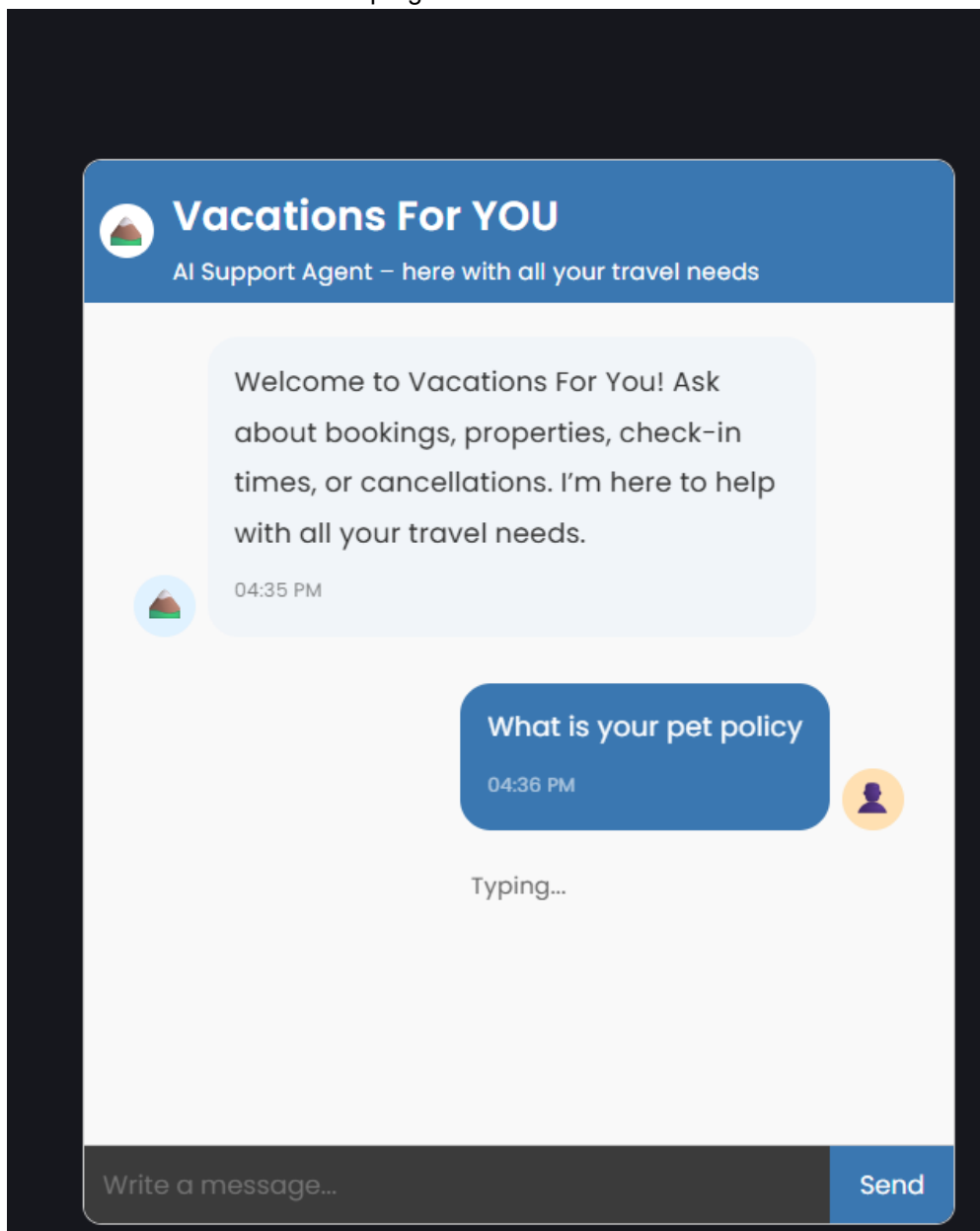
5. Using the Chatbot

5.1 Asking a General Question

21. Type a question in the input bar at the bottom of the chat.
22. Press Enter or click Send.
23. The bot will respond within a few seconds. A 'Typing...' indicator appears while it processes.

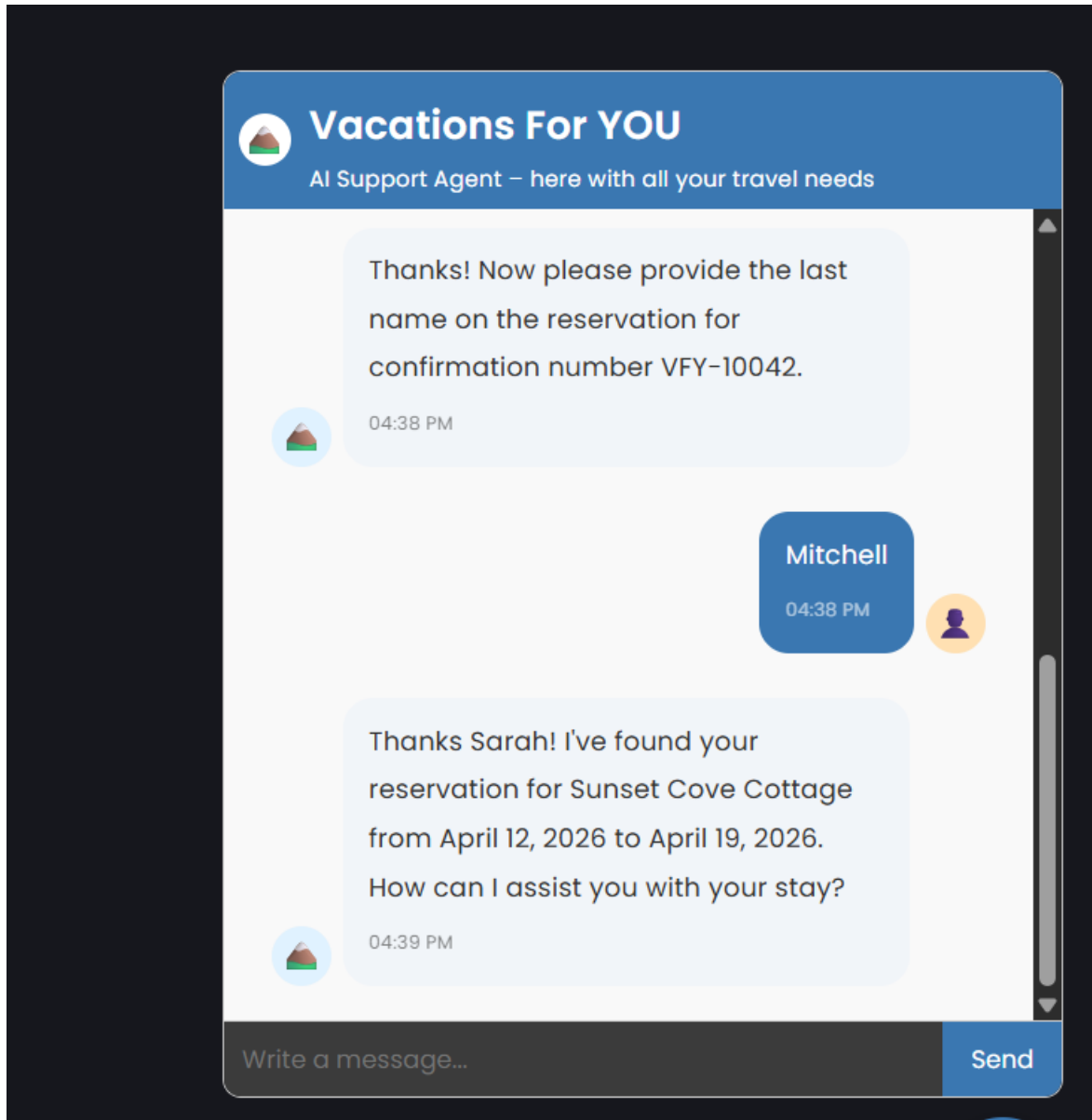
Example questions to try:

- Do you have cabins in Tennessee?
- What is your cancellation policy?
- Are pets allowed?
- What is there to do near your Georgia properties?
- How does the rewards program work?



5.2 Looking Up a Reservation

24. Type: I have a reservation
25. The bot will ask for your confirmation number.
26. Enter one of the test confirmation numbers (see Section 7).
27. The bot will ask for the last name on the reservation.
28. Enter the matching last name.
29. The bot will confirm the reservation and personalize all further responses.



Confirmation numbers are case insensitive. VFY-10042 and vfy-10042 both work. Last names are also case insensitive.

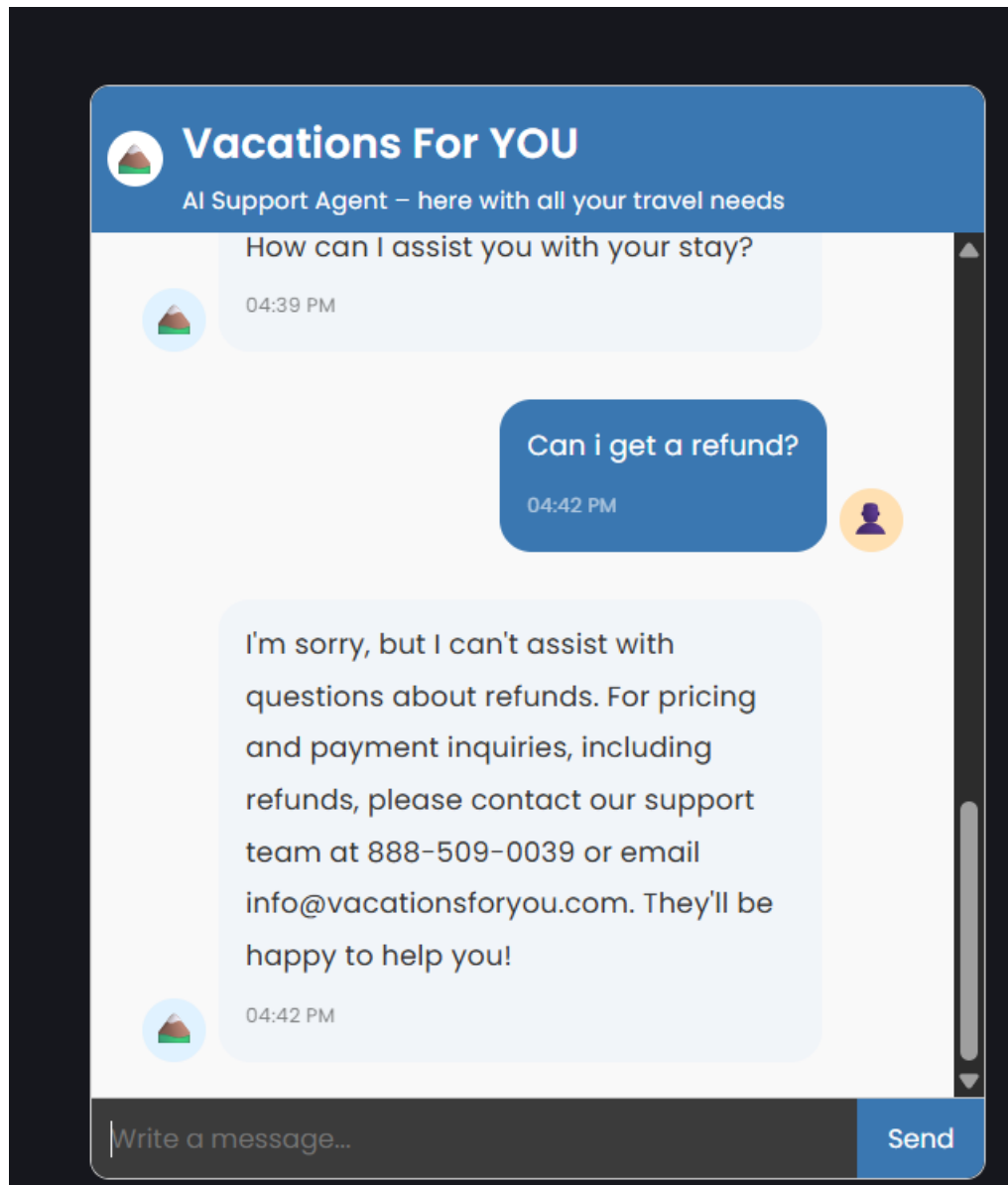
5.3 Out-of-Scope Questions

Some questions are outside the chatbot's scope. Try these to see escalation in action:

- Can I get a refund?

- Can you cancel my reservation?
- How much does it cost to book?

The bot will politely decline and provide the support team with contact information.



5.4 Session Timeout

Sessions automatically expire after 30 minutes of inactivity. If a guest sends a message after the timeout, they will receive a session expired and need to start a new conversation.

6. Viewing Logs and Sessions

6.1 Terminal Logs

Every interaction is printed to the backend terminal as a JSON log entry in real time. Each entry contains:

- timestamp — when the message was sent (UTC)
- session_id — unique ID for this conversation
- user_message — what the guest typed
- bot_reply — what the bot responded
- confidence — HIGH_CONFIDENCE, PARTIAL_CONFIDENCE, or OUT_OF_SCOPE

```
(venv) PS C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\backend> py chatbot.py
e-aware objects to represent datetimes in UTC: datetime.datetime.now(datetime.UTC).
if (datetime.utcnow() - last_active).total_seconds() > time_out_minutes * 60:
C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\backend\chatbot.py:125: DeprecationWarning: datetime.datetime.utcnow() is deprecated and scheduled for removal in a future version. Use timezone-aware objects to represent datetimes in UTC: datetime.datetime.now(datetime.UTC).
    session["last_active"] = datetime.utcnow()
C:\Users\dulci\vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant\backend\chatbot.py:84: DeprecationWarning: datetime.datetime.utcnow() is deprecated and scheduled for removal in a future version. Use timezone-aware objects to represent datetimes in UTC: datetime.datetime.now(datetime.UTC).
    timestamp = datetime.utcnow().isoformat()
LOG: {"timestamp": "2026-05-06T20:35:03.761348", "session_id": "dee3953f-a1a2-4b7a-8d3c-11f3c56087f3", "user_message": "Are pets allowed?", "bot_reply": "Pet policies vary by property and destination. In the Alabama Gulf Coast, for example, there are pet-friendly options available. For specific information about a particular property, I recommend checking the listing on our website or contacting our support team at 888-509-0039 or info@vacationsforyou.com for assistance. We're here to help!", "confidence": "HIGH_CONFIDENCE"}
CONTEXT USED: ...
127.0.0.1 - - [06/May/2026 16:35:03] "POST /chat HTTP/1.1" 200 -
127.0.0.1 - - [06/May/2026 16:35:29] "OPTIONS /chat HTTP/1.1" 200 -
LOG: {"timestamp": "2026-05-06T20:35:32.753495", "session_id": "dee3953f-a1a2-4b7a-8d3c-11f3c56087f3", "user_message": "What is your cancellation policy?", "bot_reply": "I'm sorry, but I don't have information about our cancellation policy. For detailed assistance regarding cancellations, please contact our support team at 888-509-0039 or email us at info@vacationsforyou.com. They'll be happy to help you!", "confidence": "OUT_OF_SCOPE"}
CONTEXT USED: ...
127.0.0.1 - - [06/May/2026 16:35:32] "POST /chat HTTP/1.1" 200 -
127.0.0.1 - - [06/May/2026 16:36:23] "OPTIONS /chat HTTP/1.1" 200 -
LOG: {"timestamp": "2026-05-06T20:36:27.622965", "session_id": "05c71475-6261-4b72-b1d4-4a93c924e8c6", "user_message": "What is your pet policy", "bot_reply": "Our pet policy varies by property. Many of our vacation rentals, especially along the Alabama Gulf Coast, offer pet-friendly options. However, specific pet policies, including any associated fees, can differ from one property to another. For detailed information about the pet policy for a specific property, I recommend checking the property listing on our website or contacting our support team at 888-509-0039 or info@vacationsforyou.com. They'll be happy to assist you!", "confidence": "HIGH_CONFIDENCE"}
CONTEXT USED: ...
127.0.0.1 - - [06/May/2026 16:36:27] "POST /chat HTTP/1.1" 200 -
127.0.0.1 - - [06/May/2026 16:38:38] "OPTIONS /chat HTTP/1.1" 200 -
LOG: {"timestamp": "2026-05-06T20:38:38.954533", "session_id": "f4878618-d9a8-420a-98bf-d6f3a139ff53", "user_message": "I have a reservation", "bot_reply": "Sure! Please share your confirmation number and I'll pull up your reservation.", "confidence": "HIGH_CONFIDENCE"}
127.0.0.1 - - [06/May/2026 16:38:38] "POST /chat HTTP/1.1" 200 -
127.0.0.1 - - [06/May/2026 16:38:49] "OPTIONS /chat HTTP/1.1" 200 -
LOG: {"timestamp": "2026-05-06T20:38:50.095730", "session_id": "f4878618-d9a8-420a-98bf-d6f3a139ff53", "user_message": "VFY-10042", "bot_reply": "Thanks! Now please provide the last name on the reservation for confirmation number VFY-10042.", "confidence": "HIGH_CONFIDENCE"}
127.0.0.1 - - [06/May/2026 16:38:50] "POST /chat HTTP/1.1" 200 -
127.0.0.1 - - [06/May/2026 16:38:59] "OPTIONS /chat HTTP/1.1" 200 -
LOG: {"timestamp": "2026-05-06T20:39:00.058345", "session_id": "f4878618-d9a8-420a-98bf-d6f3a139ff53", "user_message": "Mitchell", "bot_reply": "Thanks Sarah! I've found your reservation for Sunset Cove Cottage from April 12, 2026 to April 19, 2026. How can I assist you with your stay?", "confidence": "HIGH_CONFIDENCE"}
127.0.0.1 - - [06/May/2026 16:39:00] "POST /chat HTTP/1.1" 200 -
127.0.0.1 - - [06/May/2026 16:42:03] "OPTIONS /chat HTTP/1.1" 200 -
LOG: {"timestamp": "2026-05-06T20:42:05.564947", "session_id": "f4878618-d9a8-420a-98bf-d6f3a139ff53", "user_message": "Can I get a refund?", "bot_reply": "I'm sorry, but I can't assist with questions about refunds. For pricing and payment inquiries, including refunds, please contact our support team at 888-509-0039 or email info@vacationsforyou.com. They'll be happy to help you!", "confidence": "OUT_OF_SCOPE"}
CONTEXT USED: ...
127.0.0.1 - - [06/May/2026 16:42:05] "POST /chat HTTP/1.1" 200 -
```

6.2 Context Used Log

For policy questions, the terminal also prints a CONTEXT USED: line showing the first 200 characters of the manual chunk that was used to generate the response. This confirms that RAG is working correctly.

6.3 Sessions Endpoint

30. Make sure the backend is running.
31. Open a browser and go to: <http://localhost:5000/logs>
32. You will see a JSON response showing all active sessions, their states, reservation data, and conversation histories.

```
localhost:5000/logs

Pretty-print ☐

[
  {
    "history": [],
    "last_active": "Wed, 06 May 2026 20:35:29 GMT",
    "pending_confirmation": null,
    "reservation": null,
    "state": "normal"
  },
  {
    "history": [],
    "last_active": "Wed, 06 May 2026 20:36:23 GMT",
    "pending_confirmation": null,
    "reservation": null,
    "state": "normal"
  },
  {
    "history": [],
    "last_active": "Wed, 06 May 2026 20:42:03 GMT",
    "pending_confirmation": null,
    "reservation": {
      "check_in": "April 12, 2026",
      "check_out": "April 19, 2026",
      "first_name": "Sarah",
      "last_name": "Mitchell",
      "property": "Sunset Cove Cottage"
    },
    "state": "normal"
  }
]
```

7. Test Data

Three mock reservations are built into the system for testing. Use these during development and demos.

Confirmation	Last Name	Property	Check-in	Check-out	Payment Status
VFY-10042	Mitchell	Sunset Cove Cottage	April 12, 2026	April 19, 2026	Paid in Full
VFY-10087	Torres	Blue Ridge Mountain Cabin	May 3, 2026	May 10, 2026	Deposit Paid
VFY-10155	Park	Gulf Shore Villa	June 21, 2026	June 28, 2026	Unpaid

These reservations are hardcoded in chatbot.py inside the waiting_for_last_name state handler. Update them to match real StreamlineVRS data once the live connection is active.

8. StreamlineVRS Connection

8.1 Testing the Connection

33. Make sure your .env has STREAMLINE_TOKEN_KEY, STREAMLINE_TOKEN_SECRET, and STREAMLINE_BASE_URL filled in.

34. Run the connection test:

```
py test_connection.py
```

35. Read the result:

Response	Meaning	Action
Status 200 + data	Connected and working	You are live. No further action needed.
E0010 — Token invalid	Credentials don't match this URL	Contact sponsor for updated token key and secret.
E0012 — IP access denied	Your IP is not whitelisted	Send your IP (from whatismyip.com) to the sponsor to whitelist.
Connection error	Wrong URL or server unreachable	Check STREAMLINE_BASE_URL in .env. URL rotates monthly.

8.2 Monthly Credential Rotation

StreamlineVRS rotates the base URL and credentials monthly. The URL format is https://[month]-web.4vrs.com/api/json (e.g. apr-web, may-web). When you see E0010 or a connection error at the start of a new month:

36. Contact Matthew Shadle at Vacations for YOU for the new token key, token secret, and base URL.

37. Update STREAMLINE_TOKEN_KEY, STREAMLINE_TOKEN_SECRET, and STREAMLINE_BASE_URL in your .env file.

38. Run py test_connection.py again to confirm.

Credentials expire monthly. If the chatbot stops connecting at the start of a new month, this is almost always the cause.

9. Updating the Call Center Manual

When the call center manual is updated, the RAG vector store must be rebuilt. This takes about 2-3 minutes.

39. Obtain the updated manual PDF from the sponsor or team lead.

40. Replace VFYmanual.pdf in the backend/ folder with the new version.

41. Delete the existing chroma_db/ folder:

```
rmdir /s /q chroma_db    (Windows)
rm -rf chroma_db         (Mac/Linux)
```

42. Rebuild the vector store:

```
py ingest.py
```

43. Restart the backend:

```
py chatbot.py
```

44. Run the evaluation to confirm accuracy has not regressed:

```
py evaluate.py
```

The manual PDF and chroma_db/ folder is both gitignored. Never commit them to GitHub.

10. Troubleshooting Common Errors

Error	Cause	Fix
ModuleNotFoundError: No module named 'flask'	venv is not active or packages not installed	Run <code>.\venv\Scripts\activate</code> then <code>pip install flask flask-cors openai python-dotenv requests</code>
Error connecting to server (in browser)	Flask backend is not running	Run <code>py chatbot.py</code> in the backend terminal
Vector store loaded — but RAG answers seem wrong	chroma_db is stale or built from wrong manual	Delete <code>chroma_db/</code> and rerun <code>py ingest.py</code>
E0010 — Token invalid	Credentials don't match the URL	Get updated credentials from sponsor
E0012 — IP access denied	Your IP is not whitelisted	Send IP from whatismyip.com to sponsor
Can't open <code>test_connection.py</code> — file not found	Running from wrong folder	<code>cd backend</code> first then run <code>py .\test_connection.py</code>
<code>npm run dev</code> fails — vite not found	npm install not run	<code>cd frontend</code> then <code>npm install</code>
Chat shows blank — no welcome message	React state not initializing	Hard refresh browser with <code>Ctrl+Shift+R</code>
Session expired immediately	Timeout set too short in <code>chatbot.py</code>	Check <code>timeout_minutes</code> value in <code>/chat</code> route — should be 30

11. Security Checklist

Before committing or pushing to GitHub, verify the following:

Item	Check
.env is in .gitignore	Run git status — .env must NOT appear
.env.example has no real values	Open .env.example — should only contain placeholder text
VFYmanual.pdf is in .gitignore	Run git status — VFYmanual.pdf must NOT appear
chroma_db/ is in .gitignore	Run git status — chroma_db/ must NOT appear
No API keys in any .py or .tsx file	Search the codebase for sk- and token_ to confirm no hardcoded keys
HTTPS used for all external calls	All API calls use https:// URLs

If .env appears in git status, run: `git rm --cached .env` before pushing.

12. Appendix

Project	VacationsForYOU AI Guest Support Assistant
Version	1.0 — Milestone 3
Audience	Next development team
Date	Spring 2026
Repository	github.com/CGrogan4/vacationsforyou-ai-support-assistant
Team	Cassidie Grogan · Kendal Elison · Ezra Begashaw · Benjamin Dulcio · Wilfred Faltz